



It is not without reason that such a practice is rampant. The Social Justice Department fixes an annual target of a minimum of 100 marriages to be conducted in each district. In a situation where there is a dearth of couples to be married off, the already-married are made to marry again. Also, after a spate of farmer suicides in the Vidarbha region, the prime minister's relief package set aside funds for mass marriages, wherein even the organiser of the event was entitled to get Rs 1,000 per couple. Officials of the state Women and Child Welfare Department, which implements these marriages, say the organisers often do not give a fair audit of how the funds are spent. In 2006-07, the department conducted 11,132 marriages and spent Rs 12.77 crore. However, at the rate of Rs 11,000 per couple, the amount spent is still more than what it should have been—Rs 12.24 crore. The difference of Rs 53 lakh has not even been mentioned in the records.

There are other ways of earning too. The very next day after being remarried, Shivram decided to sell off his

BLESSINGS: BJP MLA Atul Deshkar hands out gifts to the newlyweds. His charge—Rs 1,500 per person

wife's mangalsutra, as he was in dire need of money. "I thought I would receive about Rs 6,000, based on what the officials told me about its worth. However, it didn't fetch me more than Rs 3,000," informs Shivram. The organisers had also promised Rs 4,000 worth of household utensils per couple. But what Shivram received was not worth more than Rs 1,600.

Mass marriage is not just a social welfare scheme, it provides ample political mileage to the parties. Most of the events are conducted by politicians themselves or organisations funded by them. Atul Deshkar, a BJP MLA from

Brahmapuri, has conducted around 90 marriages in 286 villages and gifted clothes and utensils to the couples, using the party's funds. However, in lieu of conducting these marriages, Deshkar took Rs 1,500 from each bride and groom. He defends: "It is expensive to conduct mass marriages. However, from next year onwards only Re 1 will be charged." Deshkar admits to having raised the required funds of Rs 4.5 lakh from builders and businessmen of his area. Besides getting publicity for the cause, politicians earn brownie points with the relatives of the couples present at the venue.

Congress MLA from Chimur, Vijay Wadettiwar, who recently conducted a mass marriage at the cost of Re 1, says that the Government should verify the marriage affidavits before granting funds for marriage. "I have heard of instances where organisers play foul while conducting these marriages. Unlike in western Vidarbha, organisers in eastern Vidarbha don't get any money to conduct marriages," he says. S.G. Samarth, the tehsildar of Chandrapur district, adds, "Officials take advantage of the fact that tribals have a very different method of getting married, unlike any other castes or class. They then get the tribals married in the so-called correct manner."

Last week, Hariram Madavi, the project officer of Chandrapur, claimed in a press conference to have conducted 700 marriages and spent Rs 52 lakh. This was widely reported by all the newspapers. However, when questioned on why only Rs 52 lakh was spent against Rs 70 lakh that was allocated, Madavi merely said that the papers made a "typing error".

Even after such swindles, the Social Justice Department is proposing to increase funds allocated to the Kanyadan scheme. "We want to increase the allocation from Rs 10,000 to Rs 15,000 per couple, with the government's approval," says J.N. Rathod, deputy secretary of the department. In a survey in 2006, the Government found that in the six crisis-hit districts of Vidarbha there were over three lakh families who couldn't afford to marry off their daughters. The benefits of the scheme can't be ignored in such cases. But if only there was some honesty in the exercise.

WEDDING PLANNER

Social Justice Department		
Year	Marriages	Funds
2005-06	1,445	1.44 crore
2006-07	1,077	1.07 crore
Women and Child Welfare Department		
2006-07	11,132	12.77 crore